

He loved the clergy and the poor; he was a good man and sagacious, kindly and courteous, and at the time of his ordination Laurentius also was ordained because of a dissension in the bishopric,¹

He was ordained on the same day with Laurentius because there was a dissension,

Symmachus in the basilica of Constantine and Laurentius in the basilica of the blessed Mary.

Wherefore

one party of the clergy and also of the senators was divided from the rest

the clergy was separated into parties and the senate also was divided

and some supported Symmachus and others Laurentius. And after the dissension had arisen

they all alike

the parties

decided that both factions should betake themselves to Ravenna for the judgment of Theodoric.² And

when they had come

when they had both arrived at Ravenna

they received this righteous judgment, that he who had been first ordained or who

was supported by

was known to have

the largest party should occupy the apostolic see. Thus through justice and perception of the truth Symmachus was selected and made bishop. At that time Pope Symmachus assembled a synod and appointed Laurentius bishop of the town of Nuceria out of compassion.³

¹ There is no mention here of the theological and political reasons underlying the split in the Roman church but the situation may be better appreciated if the reader recalls the beginning of discord under Anastasius II. *Supra*, p. 114 and n. 3. Laurentius seems to have been the candidate of the party that desired more compromise with the Eastern church.

² Other versions of the story say that the contending parties were forced to accept the arbitration of Theodoric. Duchesne, *op. cit.*, p. 263, n. 4.

³ The acts of the synod of Italian bishops, held under the presidency of Symmachus in 499, have been preserved. They consist chiefly of measures to prevent confusion in